



Raffles Institution
2025 Year 5 Promotion Examination
General Certificate of Education Advanced Level
Higher 1

GENERAL PAPER

8881/02

Paper 2

25 September 2025

INSERT

1 hour 30 minutes

READ THESE INSTRUCTIONS FIRST

This Insert contains the passages for comprehension.

Passage 1. *An author writes in praise of hustle culture.*

- 1 The term 'hustle' has become ubiquitous. It adorns motivational posters, fuels social media feeds, and even finds its way onto our morning coffee mugs. But beneath the trendy facade lies a truth as old as time: there's no shortcut to achieving your dreams. While some decry the hustle as a glorification of burnout, a closer look reveals a different story. The hustle, when harnessed effectively, is not the enemy; it is the engine that propels us towards our goals. 5

- 2 Let's face it, success rarely lands in our laps like a ripe apple. The greatest achievements, from groundbreaking scientific discoveries to heart-wrenching novels, are built on a foundation of relentless effort. It's about putting in the 'blood, sweat, and tears', as the saying goes, and the willingness to go the extra mile when others take a comfortable stroll. Imagine the Wright Brothers toiling away in their workshop, powered by the dream of human flight. Or picture Marie Curie, hunched over lab benches long after the rest of Paris had gone to sleep. Their journeys to the top weren't paved with laziness; they were fuelled by the fire of the hustle. 10

- 3 However, before we all don metaphorical hard hats and charge headlong into the fray, it's crucial to understand that the hustle isn't just about blind action. It's about channelling our efforts into something meaningful. The key ingredient is passion. It's the artist who can't resist losing themselves in a world of colours, the entrepreneur who wakes up with a million concepts swirling in their head, and the coder who finds poetry in the logic of algorithms. This passion fuels the hustle, transforming it from a mindless grind into a thrilling chase. It's that feeling of being 'in the flow', where time dissolves and work feels exhilarating. 15 20

- 4 The hustle is also not meant to be a lonely pursuit. Building an effective support system is crucial. Surround yourself with people who share your vision. Keep close to those who believe in you even when you doubt yourself. These allies become your important cheerleaders. They're the ones who pick you up when you stumble and celebrate your victories with unrestrained joy. 25

- 5 Finally, let's not get caught up in the societal definition of success. Success isn't a one-size-fits-all proposition. The hustle that propels one person to the top of the corporate ladder might not be the path for the artist seeking inner peace through their craft. Define success on your own terms and what truly sets your soul on fire. Is it building a thriving business, writing the next great American novel, or simply finding a job that allows you to live a life you love? 30

- 6 So, the next time you see someone hustling, don't judge them for being 'obsessed' or a victim of the 'grind'. Recognise the passion that drives them, the determination that fuels their journey. The hustle isn't a badge of shame; it's a testament to the human spirit's unwavering pursuit of dreams. It's about taking the raw material of our desires and shaping them into something tangible, something remarkable. The world needs dreamers, yes, but it also needs those with the grit and determination to turn those dreams into reality. And that, my friends, is where the true hustle comes in—a powerful force that can take us from the land of *what ifs* to the summit of our own potential. 35 40

Passage 2. *An author encourages the practice of slowing down to reflect.*

- 1 Recently, one of my students returned from an overseas exchange programme. He excitedly shared with me a new discovery he made. “For the first time in my life”, he said, “I learned to reflect”.

- 2 This was not an isolated incident. It is a silent crisis in the culture of our youths in today’s competitive environment. I have seen increasingly more students come to higher education without having truly engaged in self-reflection. Instead, every student I spoke to pointed to a culture of achievement they are engulfed in, pressuring them to constantly chase measurable outcomes, be it grades or portfolio enhancements. 5

- 3 Introspective activities are sidelined because pausing to reflect feels like stagnant inactivity which does not seem to contribute directly to any measurable progress. Yet, real growth requires time. When we set aside time to reflect, we give ourselves the space to learn more about ourselves so that we can grow personally and develop emotional maturity. This entails helping us understand how our moods can influence our perceptions and decisions, and how all this can reduce the feeling that we are being swept away by events or emotions. 10 15

- 4 Furthermore, reflection can be used to turn failures into valuable learning opportunities. There have been occasions where I’ve been upset because a situation did not go my way and I found myself repeatedly blaming myself through the day. When I finally sat down to reflect, I was able to assess and identify aspects where the incident was beyond my control, play out ways I could have handled the situation differently, and from this act of reflection, identify what I needed to better prepare should similar situations occur. 20

- 5 Reflection can also be applied to our successes in life. As we introspect, we gain insights into our own positive abilities and grow appreciative of the people and circumstances that helped make those successes possible. 25

- 6 In the absence of self-reflection, people bury themselves in work or digital distractions as an escape from processing deeper emotions. This avoidance exacerbates mental stress, turning unaddressed thoughts into psychological burdens. 30

- 7 By integrating self-reflection into our daily lives, we can shift the focus away from merely doing more to becoming more—more intentional in what we pursue and more prepared for the complexities of life.

Passage 3. *An entrepreneur talks about his opinion of hustle culture.*

- 1 I'll admit it. I was a hustler. Back in the early 1990s, I ran my first business out of my dorm room. I'd get up at 4.45 am, log a few hours of work, then race off to class. Then, I'd rush back in the afternoon to check my faxes and get on the phone with customers. At night, my business partner and I took turns grabbing a couple hours of sleep on the floor. 5
- 2 Now, the entrepreneurial world is re-examining its relationship with work-life balance—and rightly so. Elon Musk broke into tears describing to the New York Times how his 120-hour workweeks damaged his life and business, claiming how these were the “most excruciating years of my career”.
- 3 We've probably all logged 60-, 70-, even 80-hour weeks. It sounds heroic, but to be honest, after a certain point, it's unproductive. Good hustle requires constant quality control. You can't just set it and forget it. 10
- 4 So instead, I pause a lot more now to reflect when projects come my way. I ask myself: “Is this worth my time? Is this what I want to do?”. And if it is not, I find it easy to let that hustle go. 15